Ethics of AI
Independent Research
Prof. Evan Selinger

Overview

You will conduct independent research on one of five AI ethics topics that we either haven't covered in class or that expand on previous discussions. The assignment has three components, which collectively are worth 40% of the grade you will receive for this course.

- *Research Portfolio*: worth 40% of the independent research grade. It's due on November 10th in the Assignments section of MyCourses.

- *Collaborative Engagement*: worth 10% of the independent research grade. The engagement involves four posts to the MyCourses Discussion Board.

    - Post Your Question: 2.5% of research paper grade (Due November 14th).
    - Help a Classmate: 2.5% of research paper grade (Due November 17th).
    - Post Your Portfolio Entry: Required for feedback (Due November 19th).
    - Provide Peer Feedback: 5% of research paper grade (Due November 24th).

- *Research Paper (with AI Reflection Section)*: worth 50% of the independent research grade. It's due on December 10th in the Assignments section of MyCourses.

Learning Objectives

- Apply relevant ethical concepts, principles, and values to rigorously analyze current uses of AI.

- Carefully synthesize and critically evaluate peer-reviewed AI ethics scholarship.

- Construct a well-reasoned ethical argument that acknowledges the complexity of a research topic and thoughtfully respond to counterarguments to one's position.

- Engage constructively with classmates to refine one's ideas and provide meaningful, academically sound feedback to help them further their own research.

- Critically reflect on your experience of using AI during the independent research process and meaningfully connect what you learned to broader AI ethics issues.

Step #1: Pick a Research Topic

As early in the term as possible, choose *one* of the following five topics. Each one requires you to make a detailed, well-researched, and rational ethical argument.

Topic #1: AI Rights
Should AI ever have moral rights? Don't just argue yes or no. Consider what features or capabilities might justify AI deserving moral rights. For example, if AI becomes sentient, self-aware, or autonomous, should it have the right not to be destroyed or enslaved?

Topic #2: The Ethics of Military AI
Pick one specific military AI technology (autonomous weapons, surveillance, logistics coordination, etc.) that operates with a specific level of human oversight (e.g., requiring human approval for each action, only requiring human monitoring, or acting independently without human oversight, etc.). Argue whether the technology is, overall, being used ethically or unethically, making a detailed case for your conclusion. While you must reach a clear conclusion, your argument should acknowledge the complexity of the issue and address both the benefits and harms involved.

Topic #3: The Ethics of AI in Social Relationships
Pick one specific example where AI provides humans with a social relationship (e.g., as a companion, romantic partner, caregiver, etc.) and evaluate both the ethical benefits, risks, and harms. Most of your focus should be on evaluating the quality of the relationships—how AI companions affect human well-being, social skills, and connections with other people.

Topic #4: AI in Criminal Justice
Pick one specific AI application in criminal justice (e.g., risk assessment, predictive policing, sentencing, etc.) and argue whether the technology is, overall, being used ethically or unethically, making a detailed case for your conclusion. While you must reach a clear conclusion, your argument should acknowledge the complexity of the issue and address both the benefits and harms involved.

Topic #5 Alternative Option
If you have a compelling reason to conduct research on a different AI ethics topic, you may propose an alternative.

- Identify a specific AI ethics issue that we have not discussed in our course that is narrow enough to analyze deeply within the constraints of a 3,000-word paper.

- Verify that there is sufficient peer-reviewed literature on your topic (at least 6 articles available).

- Receive approval to proceed from me via email by November 3rd.

To propose an alternative topic, send me an email with (1) your proposed topic, (2) a brief but compelling explanation of why this topic interests you more than Topics #1-#4,

and (3) include three sample peer-reviewed sources that discuss the topic.

Step #2: Create a Research Portfolio (Due November 10th in the Assignments Section of MyCourses)
The portfolio is the foundation for your research paper. Think of it as an opportunity to build your knowledge base by considering expert perspectives before reaching any conclusions.

What You Need to Do

- Find 6 peer-reviewed AI ethics articles on your topic.
- For each article, write approximately 800 words that summarize and evaluate the author's main ethical arguments.
- By summarize, I mean explain what claims the author makes to develop an ethical argument and clarify how these claims are linked to form an argument.
- By evaluate, I mean provide a detailed account of why you find the author's arguments convincing or unpersuasive. You should use the first-person pronoun "I." For example, "I am not persuaded by Smith's analysis of X because of Y and Z."

What Doesn't Count

- Articles that only describe how a technology works or how people use it.
- Non-peer-reviewed sources (e.g., blog posts, news articles, etc.).
- Articles that don't include a robust ethical discussion.

Locating Peer-Reviewed Articles
The RIT library makes it easy to locate peer-reviewed material.

1. Go to https://www.rit.edu/library/.
2. Enter your search terms.
3. Click Search.
4. Click on the "Scholarly & Peer Reviewed" box.

Additional Help
If you are unsure whether an article is appropriate, please send me an e-mail. I'll provide constructive feedback to keep you on track.

Citations
Pick a standard citation format (MLA, APA, or Chicago) and use it consistently throughout your portfolio.

Late Penalty
-5 points per day.

Portfolio Grading Rubric

- Students selected quality sources that advance clear, thoughtful, and relevant ethical arguments (20%).

- Students provided a clear and rigorous summary that accurately explains the author's ethical arguments, evidence, and reasoning (40%).

- Students provided a clear and rigorous critical evaluation that analyzes the strengths, weaknesses, and persuasiveness of the author's ethical position (40%).

- Each portfolio entry should be approximately 800 words. Entries significantly under or over the recommended word count may receive point deductions.

- If a student selected an inappropriate source (e.g., not peer-reviewed or with low-quality ethical analysis), they will lose points and be asked to replace them.

Step #3: Share Research with Classmates (November 14th-17th)
After you've completed your research portfolio, you are ready to begin the collaborative engagement component of this assignment. This is an opportunity to create a research community that offers thoughtful peer feedback. Begin by sharing a research question with your classmates.

Step 3A: Post A Research Question on the MyCourses Discussion Board (Due November 14th)

What To Do
Write a post on the Discussion Board that poses a specific and significant question that your research portfolio motivated you to think about.

For example:

- "Three of my articles argue that predictive policing algorithms perpetuate racial bias. However, two others claim the bias comes from how human officers use the technology, not from the algorithms themselves. How should I evaluate these competing claims about where the ethical responsibility lies?"

- "One of my articles argues that AI companions reduce loneliness. However, another one argues that over time, the use of AI companions will make it harder for people to form human relationships. Both studies seem methodologically sound. How do I weigh short-term benefits against long-term harms?"

- "My military AI articles use different definitions of 'autonomy,' and these different definitions make a significant impact on the ethical claims each author presents. How should I address the lack of consistency?"

Step 3B: Help a Classmate (Due November 17th)

What To Do
Read one of your classmates' posts and respond thoughtfully to it on the Discussion Board. Prioritize responding to posts that haven't received responses. In your reply, be as specific and detailed as possible.

Step #4: Additional Peer Feedback (November 19th-24th)
Help a classmate improve their work by sharing one of your portfolio entries and providing constructive feedback on someone else's entry.

What To Do

- Post one of your completed portfolio entries along with the research article that you have summarized and evaluated to the Discussion Board (by November 19th).

- Choose one classmate's posted portfolio entry and provide approximately 400 words of helpful feedback (by November 24th).

What Your Feedback Should Focus On

- Is their summary of the article clear?

- Did they pick an article that makes useful points, given the research topic they chose?

- Is their assessment of the article clear?

- Is their assessment of the article thoughtful and detailed?

- Do you find their assessment of the article persuasive?

- Is anything important missing or underdeveloped in their ethical analysis?

- What's your favorite thing about their entry?

How to be Helpful

- Be specific ("Your explanation of the author's deontological argument needs more detail" vs. "This needs work").
- Suggest concrete improvements ("Try adding a sentence explaining why this ethical principle matters to your overall analysis").
- Be respectful and constructive.
- Focus on the ethical analysis, not writing style.

Late Penalty
Discussion posts submitted after deadlines will receive a -5 points deduction per day late (maximum 3 days late accepted). After 3 days, no credit will be given as the collaborative nature of these assignments requires timely participation.

Step #5: Write Your Research Paper (Due December 10th in the Assignments Section)

Basic Requirements

- Approximately 3,000 words (not including the AI Reflection).
- Present your ethical position on your chosen topic.
- In a logical and contextually appropriate manner, discuss (and cite) all 6 articles from your portfolio.
- Include a Counterargument section that presents and responds to the strongest possible objection to your own ethical position.
- Include an AI Reflection section (see below).

Ethical Position
You do not need to pick a single ethical framework for your analysis. Indeed, you may apply a variety of ethical concepts, principles, and values. What matters is that the ethical dimensions of your paper are crystal clear.

How to Structure Your Paper

1. **Introduction**
   What's your topic? Why does it have important ethical dimensions? And what's the main ethical position that you will advance?

2. **Background**
   What do the scholarly sources in your research portfolio say about this issue? What's your take on their positions? How have these articles informed your understanding of the ethical dimensions of the topic?

3. **Your Argument**
   In full detail, what's your ethical argument?

4. **Counterargument**
   Identify and respond to the strongest objection to your ethical position. Don't pick something easy to dismiss—choose the most compelling criticism someone might make. Then, you should either refute the objection or acknowledge how it reveals genuine limitations in your position (while explaining why your view remains stronger overall).

5. **Conclusion**
   Sum up your position and clarify its practical implications for individuals and society.

6. **AI Reflection**
   See the requirements below.

AI Reflection Section (approximately 300 words)
You must use a generative AI tool (e.g., ChatGPT, Claude, etc.) a few times while working on this assignment. Specifically, you should ask it relevant questions about your topic or your writing.

Be a Critical Thinker
You don't have to accept any AI suggestions. Indeed, you can reject anything it recommends!

In your reflection section, answer the following questions.

- How specifically did you use AI? (e.g., brainstorming, research help, editing, argument development, etc.).

- What did you learn about AI's abilities and limitations through this experience?

- Does your personal experience of using AI connect to the ethical issues you researched or that we covered in class? What, if any, insights does this provide about AI's role in academic work, research, or society?

- Did this experience change your perspective on any aspect of AI ethics?

Citation and Sources

Use the same standard citation format (MLA, APA, or Chicago) throughout your paper. When you mention someone else's ideas or include a passage from their writing, give them credit with proper citations.

Final Paper Grading Rubric

- Students presented a well-reasoned, clearly developed ethical position with strong supporting evidence (35%).
- Students effectively integrated summary and evaluation material from all 6 research portfolio sources (35%).
- Students effectively presented and responded to a compelling counterargument (10%).
- The AI Engagement Reflection demonstrated a thoughtful connection between personal AI use and course concepts (10%).
- The student's writing was clear, logical, and demonstrated graduate-level academic expression (10%).

Late Penalty

-5 points per day. Papers not submitted by December 16th will receive a 0.

Emergency Extensions

If an emergency arises, I will grant an extension for any component of this assignment, so long as you contact me before it is due.